

Overview: Self-Regulation Tools

Self-regulation tools help pupils identify how they are feeling, access strategies to manage big emotions, and return to a state where learning is possible. This includes simplified emotion scales (like zones of regulation), break cards, calm corner protocols, sensory tools, movement breaks, and explicit teaching of self-monitoring skills. The goal is to move from adult-led regulation to pupil-led self-awareness and action.

When to Use This Strategy

- Pupil becomes dysregulated quickly with little warning
- Escalates from calm to crisis with no middle ground
- Cannot identify or name how they are feeling
- Relies entirely on adults to notice and intervene
- Struggles to return to learning after emotional incidents
- Sensory overload leads to meltdown or shutdown

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Introduce a simple emotion scale

Use a 3-5 point scale with colours, numbers, or images. Green/1 = calm and ready. Yellow/2-3 = starting to feel wobbly. Red/4-5 = struggling, need help. Teach what each level feels like in the body.

Teacher says: "This scale shows how we're feeling inside. Green means calm, ready to learn. Yellow means something's not quite right. Red means I need help now."

Tip: Keep it simple. Three levels is enough to start. Add nuance later.

2 Teach body signals for each zone

Help the pupil connect physical sensations to the scale. Green: relaxed shoulders, normal breathing. Yellow: tight tummy, faster heart. Red: clenched fists, hot face, can't think clearly.

Teacher says: "When you're in the yellow zone, what does your body feel like? Maybe your tummy feels tight, or your hands are fidgety."

Tip: Do this when the pupil is calm—not during a crisis.

3 Introduce break cards

Give the pupil a card they can show or place on their desk to request a break without speaking. Agree where they go (calm corner) and for how long (start with 2-3 minutes). This must feel safe, not punitive.

Teacher says: "If you feel yourself moving into yellow or red, you can use your break card. No questions asked. Go to the calm corner and I'll check on you in 2 minutes."

Tip: Honour the card every time. If it feels punitive, they won't use it.

4 Set up a calm corner

Designate a low-stimulation space in the classroom. Include sensory tools (fidgets, stress ball, weighted lap pad), visual timers, breathing prompt cards, and maybe headphones. Keep it simple and accessible.

Teacher says: "This is our calm corner. When you need to reset, you can come here. There are tools to help you feel better."

Tip: Make it inviting, not a punishment space. Other pupils can use it too.

5 Teach specific regulation strategies

Explicitly teach 2-3 strategies the pupil can use: deep breathing (in for 4, out for 6), wall push-ups, squeezing a stress ball, counting backwards from 10. Practice these when calm.

Teacher says: "Let's practise our calming breaths now while we're feeling good, so your body remembers how to do it when things feel tricky."

Tip: Different strategies work for different pupils. Offer choice.

6 Build in movement breaks

Schedule regular movement breaks before dysregulation happens. This might be a "brain break" for the whole class, or a specific movement task for the pupil (delivering a message, getting equipment).

Teacher says: "Every 20 minutes, we'll have a quick movement break. Stand up, stretch, shake it out."

Tip: Proactive movement prevents reactive crisis.

7 Teach self-monitoring

Use a simple check-in routine where the pupil rates their zone at set points (start of lesson, after 15 mins, after a task). This builds awareness of their patterns.

Teacher says: "Point to your zone. Are you green, yellow, or red right now? What might help you stay green?"

Tip: Celebrate accurate self-assessment, not just being "green".

English Example: Extended writing with regulation check-ins

Year 8 pupil becomes frustrated during writing tasks. Working at KS2 level, finds sustained writing overwhelming.

Pre-task check-in

Teacher: Before starting, points to emotion scale on desk. "Point to your zone." Pupil points to green. "Good. Remember, if you move to yellow, you can use your break card."

Pupil: Points to green on scale. Acknowledges break card on desk.

Chunk task with movement

Teacher: Breaks writing into 3 sentences. "Write your first sentence, then stand up and stretch before the second." Provides stress ball for fidgeting while thinking.

Pupil: Writes first sentence. Uses stress ball. Stands and stretches. Returns to second sentence.

Mid-task check-in

Teacher: After sentence 2, quietly asks "Where are you on your scale now?" Pupil points to yellow. "Good noticing. What might help? Break card or wall push-ups?"

Pupil: Points to yellow. Chooses wall push-ups. Does 5 push-ups against the wall. Returns calmer.

Successful completion

Teacher: "You finished all three sentences and you noticed when you were getting to yellow. That's brilliant self-monitoring."

Pupil: Completes task. Identifies own regulation strategies used.

Maths Example: Problem-solving with sensory supports

Year 7 pupil becomes dysregulated when faced with unfamiliar maths problems.

Set up sensory supports

Teacher: Before lesson, places fidget cube and weighted lap pad on desk. Shows emotion scale. "These are here if you need them. No need to ask."

Pupil: Sees supports available. Places lap pad across legs.

Introduce challenging problem

Teacher: Says "This problem is tricky. It's okay to find it hard. Where are you on your scale?" Watches for signs of escalation.

Pupil: Points to green/yellow border. Picks up fidget cube.

Provide scaffolded support

Teacher: Breaks problem into steps. After each step, pauses. "Still okay? You're using your fidget cube—good strategy."

Pupil: Works through steps with fidget support. Stays regulated.

Reflect on success

Teacher: "You did a hard problem and stayed in control. What helped?" Pupil identifies lap pad and fidget cube.

Pupil: Identifies successful strategies. Builds self-awareness.

Science Example: Managing a busy practical lesson

Year 9 pupil struggles with sensory overload during practical work.

Pre-lesson preparation

Teacher: Warns pupil in advance about noisy practical. Reviews calm corner location and break card. "If it gets too loud, you can use ear defenders or your break card."

Pupil: Knows what to expect. Has ear defenders and break card ready.

Early intervention

Teacher: Notices pupil covering ears during noisy section. Quietly moves closer. "You look like you're in yellow. Ear defenders, or do you need the calm corner?"

Pupil: Takes ear defenders. Continues with reduced sensory input.

Scheduled movement break

Teacher: Halfway through, gives pupil a job. "Take this equipment back to the prep room." This provides a legitimate break from the busy environment.

Pupil: Leaves classroom briefly. Returns calmer after movement and reduced stimulation.

End of lesson check-out

Teacher: "You managed a noisy practical today. You used ear defenders and had a movement break. How are you feeling now?"

Pupil: Points to green. Identifies strategies that helped.